

quality. All the brands deserve credit for taking airflow into consideration in the design of the cabinet.

On the upgradeability front, the Compaq Presario SR1502IL and the HCL EzeeBee PI 873 came with AGP 8x graphics slots, while the Datamini and the HCL EzeeBee 4981 came with PCIe x16 slots. The others didn't have graphics slots for upgradeability. The Zenith PC, with just 128 MB of RAM, fortunately had four memory slots (out of which three were free), and hence provides good memory upgrade options. The Zenith also featured four unused SATA ports.

The best OS we saw in this category was RedHat Linux Workstation—with the HCL PCs—whereas the Compaq PCs came with FreeDOS, which is as good as not providing an OS at all. The package contents of the Compaq PCs, too, were minimal—but remember that this is the value category!

Performance

What we saw in the features was reflected in our performance tests. The HCL PI 873 and the Zenith Premium 7D, with their considerably more powerful processors, raced ahead with the highest points in the CPU tests of SiSoft Sandra and PCMark04. They also logged better scores in video as well as audio encoding, again because of their processors. It's clear that these two PCs are the best number-crunchers amongst the value-category PCs, and are the best suited of the lot for computation-intensive tasks.

In the SiSoft Sandra memory test, the LG and the Zenith failed, and the (inadequate) 128 MB of shared memory seems to have been the cause. Note here that the Zenith PC came equipped with one of the most powerful processors in this category; it was held down only because of the low amount of memory. The HCL EzeeBee PCs came with memory modules in dual-channel configuration and hence scored good points, exhibiting a healthy memory bandwidth, which is necessary for handling applications such as multimedia and image editors, database applications such as Oracle, and so forth.

The Compaq Presario SR1502IL scored the lowest in the Nero CD-

DVD speed test, and this can be blamed on the poor-quality CD-ROM drive. The Zenith and Datamini also logged very slow speeds in this test. You'll have to seriously consider upgrading your optical drive if you decide to get one of these three PCs. The Compaq Presario SG1008IL, with its better optical drive, scored the best in this test.

We could not install some games on the computers with 128 MB of RAM, because that's below the games' minimum system requirements. These PCs,



HCL EzeeBee 4981

therefore, failed our gaming tests. The HCL PCs, with 512 MB of RAM, performed well in these tests due to better graphics and more RAM. As noted earlier, these make good PCs for moderate gaming.

All the PCs in this segment, of course, came with CRT monitors. When we compared the monitors, there wasn't much variation, except that two PCs—the Compaq Presario SG1008IL and the HCL EzeeBee 4981—came with 17-inch monitors. These larger monitors were, of course, easier on the eyes.

The Zenith and the Compaq Presario SR1502IL did not bundle speakers with their PCs; all the others did. The ones on the HCL PCs sounded better than those on the others—not that the speakers were really good, they were just comparatively better.

The Zenith PC—even with its low 128 MB of RAM—was the top scorer in PCMark04, which is a synthetic benchmark used to evaluate the overall performance of a PC. The Business Winstone 2004 benchmark is a real-world benchmark; here, the HCL EzeeBee PI 873 scored 24.1, which was the best in its class. This means it can run day-to-day applications such as office software and business applications better than the other PCs in this category.



Conclusion

The PCs in this segment were not as lacklustre as we'd expected them to be—for example, like we said, we never expected to see an Athlon64 or a Pentium 4 with HT, or for that matter 512 MB of RAM, in a PC in this category. Essentially, this points to the fact that good PCs have gotten cheap.

The Compaq Presario SR1502IL is priced the lowest at Rs 17,990, and the SG1008IL—also from Compaq—is priced at Rs 19,990; Compaq is trying to make headway into the value-category market in a big way. The LG XT1 retails at Rs 25,000, which is too high for a PC with its specifications.

In the tests, the HCL PCs were always ahead of the rest, with their superior specifications, features and package bundle. In fact, they also bundled a 100-hour internet package as well as games and other software. The Datamini was not far behind, though, when we took overall points into consideration.

The HCL EzeeBee PI 873 merits special mention. It was the second-best PC in this category, featuring the powerful Athlon64 3000+ along with 512 MB of RAM. It was amongst the favourites, and was left behind only because of marginally lower scores.

We decided that the HCL EzeeBee 4381 would be the Digit Best Buy Gold winner.

PCs ABOVE Rs 25K

The PCs in this, the second category, had considerably more fire-power than the Value PCs, and came with better components; we cannot, however, call them "high-end" by any standards. Seven PCs comprised this category: the Acer Aspire SA80, Acer Aspire ASP V4324, Compaq Presario SR1630IL, Datamini Festiva MG, Datamini Festiva MG Premium, LG XD8-L92ARP1, and the Krypton Voyager 9.



Krypton Voyager 9